

Tribes in India

- Tribal people constitute 8.6% of the nation's total population, over 104 million people as per 2011 census.
- Number of Scheduled Tribes recognized in India: around 645–700 distinct tribes exist
- Tribes officially recognized under **Schedule 5** of the Indian Constitution

Major Tribes Across Regions

Include region-wise breakdown with key tribes and unique traits:

- **Central India:**
 - *Gond* — one of India's largest tribes, located across Madhya Pradesh and central India; speak Gondi
 - *Bhil* — mainly in Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP; known as skilled archers; name derives from “bow” (Bhili language)
- **Eastern India:**
 - *Santhal* and *Munda* — major tribal groups in Jharkhand, Odisha, West Bengal; with distinct languages and cultural systems
- **Northeast India:**
 - *Khasi*, *Garo*, *Bodo*, *Angami*, *Nyishi* — tribe groups with unique matrilineal structure (Garo, Khasi), handloom culture (Bodo), festivals like Hornbill (Angami)
- **Southern/Andhra Region:**
 - *Chenchu* — forest dwellers in Andhra Pradesh, tied to Nallamala Hills
- **Island Tribes:**
 - *Jarawa*, *Onge*, *Sentinele*, *Great Andamanese* — isolated tribes of Andaman & Nicobar Islands with very small populations and unique cultures
 - **Toto, Bhutia, Meena, Kora, Pardhi, Babaria** — each with unique linguistic, cultural, and geographic characteristics

Tribes spread across different parts of India

Name	State	Description
Bhils (derived from bow)	MP, Gujarat, Rajasthan, Maharashtra and north-eastern part of Tripura	• Popularly known as the bow men of Rajasthan • They forms the largest tribe of the whole South Asia • Divided into two main groups : <i>Central or pure Bhils</i> and <i>Eastern or Rajput Bhils</i>

		• They speak Bhili, which is an Indo Aryan language • Religion practice among the Bhils differ from place to place • The Baneshwar fair is the main festival celebrated during Shivratri
Munda (means headman of the village) 	Mainly Jharkhand Spread across Bihar ,WB, Chhattisgarh and Orissa	• They speak Mundari, which is a Austro- Asiatic language • Complexion is blackish. They have short curly hair. • Christianity is the main religion. • They believe in Singbonga, which means the Sun God • They remained hunters for centuries. But now they have been converted into the settled agriculturist • Mage, Phagu, Karam, Sarhul, and Sohrai are the few festivals celebrated
Santhals 	West Bengal, Bihar, Orissa, Jharkhand and Assam	• It is one of the largest tribe in India • They waged war against the permanent settlement of Lord Cornwallis in 1855. • They speak Santhali, which is a Austro- Asiatic language • They are engaged in hunting, fishing and cultivation for their livelihood • They have no temples of their own. They even do not worship any idols. Santhals follow the Sarna religion. • They mainly celebrate the Karam festival to please the God to increase their wealth and free them from all the enemies.
Gonds	Widely spread in the Chhindwara district of Madhya Pradesh, Bastar district of Chhattisgarh and also	• They are the largest tribe in Central India • They speak Gondi language which is related to the Telgu and the other Dravidian languages. In the

 Gonds Tribe	in the parts of Maharashtra, Andhra Pradesh, and Orissa.	northern parts Gonds are often seen speaking the local Hindi. • They are divided into four tribes namely - Raj Gonds, Madia Gonds, Dhurve Gonds, Khatulwar Gonds • They are largely influenced by the Hindus and for the long time have been practicing the Hindu culture and traditions • Keslapur Jathra is the important festival of the Gonds
Khasi 	Mainly found in the state of Assam and the Khasi Jaintia hills in Meghalaya Other places are Punjab, UP, Manipur, WB and J&K	• They are called by the different names such as Khasi Pahris, Khuchia, Kassi, Khashi and Khasa • Most of the Khasis follow Christianity • They speak Khasi-an Austro-Asiatic language • The property of the Khasis is passed on from the mother to the youngest daughter • The women wear silver or gold crown on their head and men wear large earrings. • Nongkrem is the major festival celebrated among the Khasi's.
Baiga 	Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Madhya Pradesh and Orissa	• They are the forest-dwelling aboriginals from central India • They do not interact with other tribal, believe in a hand-to-mouth existence. • Do not try to access education, eat outside their community, or associate with others • Tattooing is an integral part of their lifestyle
Birhor (means peoples of jungles)	Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand, Orissa	• They are known as the hunter tribe. • This tribe is a Proto-Australoid tribe, physically recognizable by their deep, dark-brown skin color and wavy, curly/frizzy black hair • The tribe is divided into two major sub-tribes, the Jaghis Birhor(wandering, practice shift

		cultivation) and Uthalu Birho(settled, follow agro-based economy) • Tanda: The settlement whether permanent or temporary, which consists of usually half a dozen or more huts • In news because the tribe struggles to maintain traditional lifestyle in the face of government intervention
Chenchus 	Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Odisha	• They live in bee hive shaped tiny huts with wattle walls • They speak Chenchu language with the Telgu accent • They worship number of deities. They mainly believe in Bhagaban taru who lives in the sky and look after them in all their doings • They are referred to as one of the Primitive Tribal Groups that are still dependent on forests and do not cultivate land but hunt for a living • Most of them inhabit in the Nallamalai hills of AP

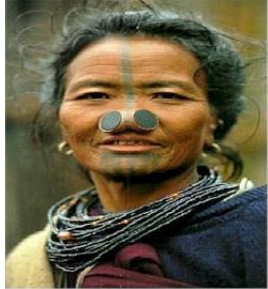
North and North-West

Name	State	Description
Gaddis 	Himachal Pradesh	• They mainly dwell around Dhauladhar mountain range, Chamba, Bharmaur and the areas near to Dharamshala • The main occupation is shepherding and they make their livelihood by rearing and selling sheep, goats, mules and horses. • Most of them are Hindus and a few Muslims • The most attractive aspect about this tribe is their attire. • They speak the Gaddi Language but for writing they use Takri and Hindi.

Pangwal	Himachal Pradesh	- They are the inhabitants of the Pangi valley of Chamba district - They are known for their charming faces, fine physique and for their love of song and dance. - They are mostly engaged in farming.
Bhutia (Baichung Bhutia? ☺) 	Sikkim	- They are also known as the Lachenpas and Lachungpas - They are of the Tibetan origin and migrated to Sikkim around 16th century. - They form 14% of the total population of Sikkim. - They usually speak Sikkimese. They also speak Lepcha, Bhutia, Nepali, English and Hindi. - A traditional Bhutia house is called a "khim" and is usually rectangular. - Losar and Losoong are the main festivals celebrated
Limbus/ Limboos 	Sikkim	- They are one of the indigenous tribe of Sikkim belonging to Nepali stock - Mongoloid looking by figure having their own language, faith, costume, culture and life style. - Their traditional group dance called Dhannach is famous usually performed in the marriage, death and any festive celebrations. - They are farmers by profession and they love enjoying their life more by singing, feasting and dancing. - The traditional dress of the Limbus is mekhli and taga.
Lepchas 	Sikkim	- They are one of the indigenous tribe of Sikkim - They look fair in complexion, shy in nature wearing generally a kind of set wear of shirt and trousers called Hontaj Gyador. - They call themselves Rong in their language. - They speak their own dialect and they too follow the same Tibetan form of Buddhism besides their local faith.
Buksa	Uttarakhand and UP	- They are one of the primitive tribal groups of India - They are indigenous people concentrated in

		the Dehradun and Nainital in the Kumaon foothills of the outer Himalayas Major occupation are agriculture and animal husbandry
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North-East

Name	State	Description
Apatani or Tanni 	Arunachal Pradesh	- They are settled agriculturists inhabiting the valley around Ziro-the headquarters of Lower Subansiri district. - They practice permanent wetland cultivation in hilly terrain by slicing the hills. - They are loyal followers of the Donyi-Polo faith, who pray to the Sun and the Moon - Men of other tribes would often steal the Apatani women, which led the Apatani men to tattoo the faces of their women and make them wear massive nose plugs, in order to make them less appealing.
Adis/ Bokar Lhoba (meaning hill or mountain top) 	Arunachal Pradesh , Assam	- They have two main divisions the Bogum and Bomis - They by nature are democratic and organized village council called Kebang - Their traditional dance called Ponung is famous in the whole of Arunachal Pradesh. - Dances are very popular among them. - The villages are situated generally on the spurs of hills - The women are very good weavers and weave cloth with highly artistic designs.

Nyishis 	Arunachal Pradesh	• They are the largest groups of people inhabiting the major part of Lower Subansiri district • Their menfolk wear their hair long and tie it in a knot just above the forehead • They are Indo-Mongoloid group of people and their language belongs to the Tibeto-Burman family. • The tribe as a whole is fond of hunting and fishing in which they perhaps excel any other neighboring tribes
Kampti 	Arunachal Pradesh	• They are a sub-group of the Shan people Lohit district. • They possess East Asian features. • They are followers of Theravada Buddhism • They have adopted a script of Shan origin, known as Lik-Tai for their language. • They are renowned for their craftsmanship.
Tagin	Arunachal Pradesh	• They are main inhabitant of Upper Sunansiri district. • Their main occupation is agriculture. • Polygamy is customary among them. • Their dress is very simple consisting of only one piece of cloth.
Angami 	Nagaland	• Tenyidie is the most common language spoken • Population is around 12 million. • Agriculture is the main occupation. • Christianity is the major religion followed • They are quite popular for their woodcraft and artwork(producer of bamboo work, cane furniture, beds, shawls and powerful machetes) • Sekrenyi is the main festival celebrated which marks the beginning of the lunar year
Rengmas	Nagaland	• They are one of the seventeen major Naga Tribes. • They follow patriarchal system. • Originally they were animist. They believed in various gods and goddess. The Christianity is also present among the tribe. • Agriculture is the main occupation. They

		practices Jhumming. Women are expert weavers. • Nyada is the main festival celebrated. This is to mark the end of the agricultural years. • Note: A section of them have migrated to Karbi Anglong districts of Assam
Sema /Sumi Nagas 	Nagaland and Assam	• They are one of the major tribes of Nagaland recognized for their martial art skills. • They mainly inhabit <i>Zunheboto</i> district. • They are most united and aggressive tribe. • Tuluni is the major festival celebrated. • They follow Christianity.
Zeliang 	Nagaland	• The Zeliang is the official name of the Zemi and Liangmei people in Nagaland • They live primarily in the south-western part of Kohima district • The Hega festival is one of the most important and the biggest festival. • They inhabit Barrail range of hills in Manipur, Nagaland and Assam. • They are very famous for their sanitation and hygiene.
Konyak (means blackhead or human) 	Nagaland	• They are the largest out of 17 officially recognized tribes in Nagaland, • They are known as 'those violent headhunters with tattooed faces.' • One of the last headhunters, they now practice agriculture and hunt seasonally • The most important festival is AolingMonyu which is celebrated in spring season and the occasion is related to the sowing of seeds. • More than 95% of them follow Christianity. • The men wear earrings made out of deer horn, necklace made out of boar tusks and brass heads.
Garos	Meghalaya	• They are the second-largest tribe in Meghalaya and comprise about a third of the local population. • They are mainly Christians. • The youngest daughter inherits the property from her mother. Sons leave the parents' house

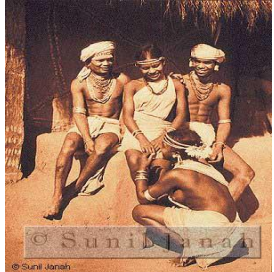
		at puberty, and are trained in the village bachelor dormitory. After getting married, the man lives in his wife's house. They are a matrilineal not matriarchal society.
Jaintias 	Meghalaya	- They are traced in the Jaintia hills. - They belong to the Proto Austroloid Monkhmer race - Basically it is a sub tribe of Khasis and since they have been residing in Jaintia hills, they have been named so. - Most of them follow Christianity - The men wear Jymphong and dhoti while the women wrap several pieces of clothes so as to give a cylindrical shape.
Reang 	Tripura	- They are the second largest tribal community of Tripura. - They are said to have come first from Shan State of upper Burma. - They belong to Indo-Mongoloid racial stock. - Their language is known as "Kaubru" which have a tonal effect of Kuki language though broadly it is Kok-Borok (language of men). - They are still a nomadic tribe and a large numbers among them maintain their livelihood involving Top Hill Jhum Cultivation, food gathering, fishing & hunting. - They follow Hindu religion.
Lushais 	Tripura	- They belong to Kuki-Chin group of tribes. - They are commonly known as Mizos. - They live on Jhum Cultivation and hunting of wild animal. They are also famous as orange producing community. - They follow Christianity as their religion. - Their Bamboo Dance (Cheraw-dance) is very much popular in and outside the country.
Kuki	Manipur	- An ethnic tribe spread across vast areas of North-eastern region of India except Arunachal Pradesh, Burma and foot hills of Chittagong hills - They form a part of the great Mongolian race

		• They prefer to live on the hill tops and their villages are cluster of houses closely constructed to protect from alien raiders. • Mainly followers of Christianity and Judaism
Bodos 	Assam	• They belong to Indo-Mongoloid family. It is believed that their origin was Tibet and China. • The speak Bodo language that is derived Tibeto Burmese family of language • Most of them are engaged in rice cultivation, tea plantation and poultry farming. Women engage themselves in weaving • They are expert in bamboo and cane craft; hence one would usually come across houses fashioned out of bamboo and wood in places where they live in majority • Some of them are Christians, while a large chunk follows the precepts of Hinduism
Mishing /Miris 	Assam	• They are the second largest schedule tribe of Assam. • As per tradition they practice group fishing in winter and group hunting in summer. The women are expert weavers. • The 'Ali-Ai-Ligang' is the most well-known and widely observed festival (festival of sowing seeds) • They have their own language, but no script: hence they use the Assamese language when the written form is required
Karbi/ Mikirs 	Assam	• They belong to the Mongoloid group and linguistically to the Tibeto-Burman group • They reside in hilly areas of Assam and form the major portion of population of Karbi Anglong district. They also inhabit places in North Cachar Hills, Nagaon and Sonitpur districts of Assam • Their main occupation is agriculture. • The place of women is same as the men, and women help their men in every step of life • Dance and Music play an important role in their life • They are mentioned as Mikir in the constitution of India.
Rahabas	Assam	• They are widely scattered but mostly

		concentrated on Goalpara, Kamrup, and Darrang. • Agriculture is the main occupation • Traditionally they were very religious. Now most of them have embraced Hinduism or Christianity. • They like to live in compact blocks having 50-100 families.
Biate (means worshipper)	Mizoram, Assam and Meghalaya	• They are also one of the oldest living tribes in the NE. • Though they are less in term of population, they have their own identity with a rich and distinctive history, culture, dialect and religious heritages..

Central India

Name	State	Description
Khonds / Dongria Khonds 	Orissa	• They are indigenous tribal groups in Orissa. • Their native language is Kui, a Dravidian language written with the Oriya script. • They are nature worshipping forest dwellers. • Vedanta Resources, mining company, was set to destroy the forests, wildlife and way of life of the Dongria Kondh people. Their four year long protests finally paid off as the government has now banned Vedanta from mining in Niyamgiri Mountain and in their forests.
Bonda 	Odisha	• They are also known as Bondo or Remo • They live in the isolated hill regions of the Malkangiri district of southwestern Odisha. • They are one among the Primitive Tribal Groups identified by GOI. • They are generally semi-clothed, the women wear thick silver neck bands. • The Gov of Orissa had setup Bonda Development Agency (BDA) in 1977 with the aim of bringing Bonda's into the mainstream
Oarons /Kurukh	Odisha ,Bihar,	• They mainly depend on agriculture for earning

	Jharkhand, WB	their living. • Most of them are engaged in the occupation of tea cultivation. • They are considered to have the second largest population of tribes in Bihar and Jharkhand • They speak Kurukh language related to Dravidian family. • Majority of them are Hindus and are religious minded people. They worship Gods and Goddesses but a great number of these tribes have adopted Christianity.
Khairwar	Madhya Pradesh	• It is on the brink of extinction because of the tribe members' inability to conceive • They reside in a remote village called Harrai. • There are only about 30 families left -- all childless couples who are either old or middle-aged and past their reproductive age.
Kol (means human)	Madhya Pradesh Other states include Bihar, UP, Chhattisgarh, Assam, Tripura	• It is one of the most ancient tribes of India, whose mention is found in the Rig Veda and many other mythological scriptures. • Most of them are landless and work on farm as laborers and sharecroppers • They prefer to live in groups near the villages called as Kolhan
Murias 	Chhattisgarh	• They are a sub-group of the Gonds and inhabit the forests and plains of central India. They live along the Indrawati River, which flows through the Bastar district. • They survive mainly by farming, hunting, and eating the fruits of the forest. • The ghotul, or temporary dormitory for unmarried youth, is a significant building within the Muria villages
Pahari Korwa/ Korba	Chhattisgarh, Bihar	• They belong to Austro-Asiatic family • The Korwas are divided into Pahari Korwa and Dihari Korwa. • The main concentration is in Jashpur, Sarguja & Raigarh. • They are medium to short height have a dark brown or black skin. • Fishing and hunting are practiced as occupation. • Karma dance is very popular dance and all the villagers participate in it.
Maria	Chhattisgarh	• Two types: Abhuj Maria and Bison Horn Maria

		• Both are sub castes of the Gond tribals. • <u>Abhui Maria:</u> ➤ They live in isolation and inhabit the secluded enclaves of Narayanpur tehsil of Bastar District ➤ They fear mankind ➤ They are one of the few tribes that have managed to keep their quintessential culture alive and unaffected by the vestiges of time • <u>Bison Horn Maria:</u> ➤ They are found in MP and Maharashtra also ➤ Their introvert nature makes them live in isolation in the interiors of dense forest areas ➤ They derived their name from their unique custom of wearing a distinctive headdress, which resembles the horns of a wild bison
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Western India

Name	State	Description
Sahariya (meaning residents of Jungle)	Rajasthan	• Only primitive tribe of Rajasthan residing in the Baran district • They follow Hindu religion and speak a dialect influenced by Hadoti. • Faced with social ignorance, anger, deprivation and inhuman treatment inherent in the system, the people of this tribe are once again in the miserable condition. • In the absence of sources of livelihood, this tribal group is again forced to resort to migration
Mina/ Meena (meaning fish)	Rajasthan	• They are found in the northern part of Rajasthan. • Originally a nomadic, warlike people practicing animal breeding and known for lawlessness, today most of them are farmers.

		- At the time of British rule, this community had been acclaimed as criminal tribe - Majority of them follow Hinduism
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South India

Name	State	Description
Irulas (meaning darkness) 	Tamil Nadu	- They are inhabitants of the scrub jungles of Southern India belonging to the Negrito (or Negroid) race - Hunter-gatherers by tradition, their expertise in catching snakes is legendary - Most of them are wage laborers working in tea estates now. - They are partly Hinduized, but have their own indigenous religious system
Badagas 	Tamil Nadu	- It is one of the oldest tribal communities in the Nilgiris. - The main occupation of the people in this community is agriculture. Tea plantation is the major agriculture here. - They are socially, educationally and even economically advanced now. - The Badaga language is a mixture of Kannada and Tamil and there is no script for this language. - They are Hindus of Shiva sect.
Kota (Ko meaning mountain) 	Tamil Nadu	- They have been living in the Nilgiri mountains for ages - They are found living only in seven settlements, referred to by them as Kokkals - They are the only artisan community on the hills of the Nilgiris - Most of the crafts practiced by them are on the decline. - The major festival is the annual Kamatra-ya festival
Kanis	Kerala	They belong to a traditionally nomadic

		community, who now lead a primarily settled life in the forests of the Agast-Hymalai hills of the Western Ghats • They have an extremely rich and unique Traditional Knowledge about the use of the resources, particularly the biological resources around them • They introduced Tropical Botanical Garden and Research Institute (TBGRI) to a medicinal plant in their forest from which a drug named 'jeevani' was isolated and commercialized
Uralis (means ruler of a locality)	Kerala and Tamil Nadu	• They are mostly found on the Idukki hills of Kerala • Agriculture is the main occupation. • They worship nature as Gods and inventor of the world. • They have their own native language called as Urali language
Lambada / Banjaras/ Sugalisa 	Andhra Pradesh	• They are the largest tribe of AP. • They live in exclusive settlements of their own called Tandas, usually away from the main village, tenaciously maintaining their cultural and ethnic identity. • They are expert cattle breeders and largely subsist by sale of milk and milk products.

Island Region

Name	State	Description
Jarawas	Andaman	• They are one of the indigenous peoples of the Andaman Islands. They have inhabited the islands for thousands of years • Their present numbers are estimated at between 250–400 individuals. • Since they have largely shunned interactions with outsiders, many particulars of their society, culture and traditions are poorly

		understood. For more details on Jarawas read this : http://mrunal.org/2013/03/rights-issue-jarawa-tribes-human-safari-buffer-area-tribal-commission-13th-schedule.html
Sentinelese 	Andaman	- They are one of the Andamanese indigenous peoples and one of the most remote tribes of the Andaman Islands. - They inhabit North Sentinel Island. - They are noted for vigorously resisting attempts at contact by outsiders. - The Sentinelese maintain an essentially hunter-gatherer society subsisting through hunting, fishing, and collecting wild plants; there is no evidence of either agricultural practices or methods of producing fire. - Their language remains unclassified.
Shompens 	Great Nicobar Island	- They are one of the last surviving stone-age tribes in the world. - They wander in their forest and coastal habitat in search of food. - They are also on the brink of extinction as the four other hunter-gatherer tribes (the Jarawa, the Andamanese, the Onge and the Sentinelese). - They are of mongoloid stock unlike the other primitive tribes of the Andaman Islands which are negrito
Onges (means 'we people') 	Little Andaman	- A negrito tribe with just 96 in number now. They are divided into 5 families comprising of 15 members in all living in South Bay - They are pure hunter-gatherers and are not aware of agriculture - They have no clear concept of religion but they are animistic.